

Pip of Bramblewick Farm



On Bramblewick Farm, where anything will grow, there is a seed shed, and in the seed shed there is an oak table, and on the oak table, on sorting morning, sat one thousand seeds — and Pip.

Pip was a sesame seed. The pumpkin seeds called Pip *small as a freckle, light as a wish*, and they did not mean it kindly. All winter they had bragged about the Big Field — how they'd be planted in long brown rows, how they'd grow so wide you could see them from the gate. Pip wanted the Big Field more than anything. Pip practiced for it, hopping down the shelf — one, two, three hops — and measuring: *taller than a raindrop, almost*.

But when Farmer Meg's hands came sorting, the sesame seeds didn't go into the field sacks. They went into the kitchen jar on the windowsill, where the glass flashed and the lid shut tight.

"Grandmother," Pip whispered to the old sunflower seed, who had been saved for seed so many years she'd been a flower more than once, "am I too small to matter?"

"A seed's worth isn't weighed in ounces, little one," said Grandmother Sunflower. "It's counted in springs."

Pip didn't understand. There wasn't time to ask. The shed door banged open, the wind came looking for something to carry, and — being exactly the size of things the wind likes best — Pip was

that something.

Over the table. Under the door, through the crack. *Cracks are for small ones*, thought Pip, tumbling. And then Pip was sitting in the middle of the farmyard, which is a very big place to be, when you are a very small seed.

The door had shut. The shed was a mountain with no way in. And every seed knows the two hard rules of spring. The last frost comes at night, and it pinches lonely seeds so cold they never grow tall. And when the planting rain ends tomorrow at sunset, every seed snug in soil will grow — and every seed that isn't will wait a whole year in the open. With the crows.

Pip looked across the yard. Far away, past the flagstones and the hen run, the Big Field lay brown and waiting.

"Well," said Pip, "I always wanted to go."



The flagstones ended at a puddle. Not a puddle — to a seed it was a sea, gray and wrinkled, wider than forty hops. And on the shore of it sat two seeds arguing.

"We climb around!" said the big one, a runner bean, shiny as a boot.

"The wall is nine seeds high. I counted. Nine!" said the round one, a sweetcorn kernel, who was shaking. He had been on that shore all morning, because he had also counted ninety-nine ways the crossing could go wrong, and the counting had stacked up so high he couldn't roll past it.

"Or," said Pip, "we could sail."

The bean looked down. And down. "Ha! Sail on what, crumb? You're barely a crumb!"

The word landed like a stone. Pip slid backward into the shadow of a leaf, where small ashamed things go, and might have stayed there all day — but the kernel rolled over, peering into the dark.

"Excuse me," he said. "Crumbs can't talk. You're a sesame seed. Sesame seeds are the lightest seeds on the whole farm. I counted everything, and you —" he tapped the fallen sycamore leaf they were standing beside "— are the only one of us this boat can carry along with me and Meanie."

"Bean," said Bean, quietly.

They pushed off. The leaf-boat wobbled, and wherever it dipped, Pip hopped to the high side — one, two, three — and it steadied. Halfway across, the kernel said, "Small as a freckle, light as a wish," and he *did* mean it kindly, and it sounded brand new.

Pip learned their names on the far shore: Bean, who had bounced off the seed cart, and who mentioned twice before sundown that he was going to be the first vine up the tallest pole on the whole farm. Kernel, who had been dropped by a crow with a full stomach and a poor grip. They were headed to the Big Field too. Everyone goes together who goes far.

That night the frost came looking.

They felt it sliding over the wall, sharp as scissors. "Frost fact," said Kernel, teeth chattering. "A seed alone in the open gets pinched too cold to grow tall. But seeds packed close keep warm. It's how sacks work. I counted the warm in a sack once. It's a lot."

So they packed close under a dock leaf, Bean in the middle because he was biggest, and in the dark Bean's voice came out smaller than he was.

"Pip. About 'crumb.' That was me being scared of the puddle and loud about it. You're the bravest cargo I ever sailed with." He paused. "Also the only."

Pip smiled in the dark. "Taller than a raindrop," Pip whispered. "Almost."



Morning came white at the edges, and the three of them unpacked themselves and looked at the last thing between them and the Big Field: the hen run.

The hens were giants. Their feet were rakes; their beaks came down like weather. The only way past was under the gate — through a gap that Pip could walk through, Kernel could squeeze through, and Bean could not fit through at all, not even breathing in.

"Hen fact," whispered Kernel. "Farmer Meg scatters corn on the far side at feeding time. Every hen runs to it. I counted the time we'd have: forty pecks' worth."

"Then Bean climbs the gate while they're busy," said Pip.

Bean went a strange color for a bean. "Easy-peasy," he said, which is what he always said when it wasn't. His voice had gone up two fence posts. "It's just — high."

There was a lovely dark knothole shadow at the bottom of the gate, exactly Pip-sized, and Pip wanted to hide in it so much it hurt. Instead, Pip stepped out of the shadow into the wide open, and went up the gate the way only the smallest seed on the farm could: hop, cling, hop — wire to wire to wire — all the way to the top of the gatepost, where a crow's shadow slid across the wood, paused... and moved on, because a sesame seed at that height looks exactly like a fleck of nothing at all. Pip's shell went cold anyway.

"Climb to me, Bean!" Pip called. "Don't look at the ground. Look at me! I'm easy to find. I'll be the smallest thing in the sky."

The corn scattered. The hens ran. And Bean climbed — one wire, two wires, three — eyes fixed on that tiny brave dot above him, while Kernel counted pecks below like a clock. At the fortieth peck, Bean tumbled down the far side into the grass, and if you have never heard a runner bean laugh with relief, it sounds like rain starting.

Which is exactly what it did. The rain came — early.



They raced the water down to the Big Field's edge. The furrows were filling, lovely and brown. "Dam fact!" Kernel shouted over the drumming. "Farmer Meg banks a little earth wall at the end of every furrow, to hold the water in! If a dam breaks, the whole furrow drains out onto the gravel path — and gravel grows nothing, ever!"

Bean settled into the soft furrow soil. Kernel rolled in beside him. And Pip — Pip was too light. The runnel water picked Pip up like a crumb off a plate and swept Pip along the furrow's edge, and just as a kind gust swooped low, offering to carry one small seed up and over, into the middle of the Big Field at last —

— Pip heard Kernel shout: "The dam! There's a gap in the dam!"

It was a tiny gap. A gap the water was already threading through, sipping the furrow away toward the gravel. A gap far too small for a bean or a kernel to plug.

A gap exactly the size of a sesame seed.

The gust waited. The Big Field waited. All winter's wanting waited.

"Oh," said Pip. "So *that's* what I'm the size of."

Pip let the gust go. Small as a freckle, light as a wish, Pip rode the runnel down the furrow's edge — one, two, three — and wedged in tight, and the dam held. Behind it the water rose soft and brown around Bean and Kernel, who were shouting Pip's name like a cheer, and the rain's own mud settled thick and snug around the gap, packing it shut the way Farmer Meg herself would have done, until the dam didn't need a sesame seed anymore.

Only then did the last sheet of rainwater, sliding along the hedge, lift Pip loose and carry Pip away — and *cracks are for small ones*: Pip caught the crack at the foot of the old fence post and tumbled to a stop in the dark hedgerow bank, in real soil, just as the sun went down and the rain ended everywhere on Bramblewick Farm.

That night was the longest one. The hedgerow corner was quiet and enormous, and the Big Field might as well have been the moon. Pip measured the dark and came up short. *Not even half a ladybird*, Pip thought. *Not even a freckle*. And a seed can't walk, and a plant never can; wherever a seed gives up its wish, it stays. Pip lay in the cold new soil and listened to the water dripping off the hedge, drop by drop by drop, and for the first time in Pip's whole small life, Pip didn't count a single one.

But morning came green at the edges. And across the field, thin as thread, came voices — "PIP! PI-IP!" — a big loud one, hoarse from shouting half the night, and a worried round one, half a beat behind it: "Ninety-nine! That's ninety-nine times we've called, Bean, what if —" "Then we call a HUNDRED, Kernel! PI-IP!" And the voices carried all the way from the furrow to the corner, and landed on Pip like sunshine.

"Taller than a raindrop!" Pip shouted back, with all the air one sesame seed can hold.
"ALMOST!"

The whole Big Field went quiet. And then it cheered.

And Bramblewick is the farm where anything will grow.



Pip grew. Oh, how Pip grew — up past the raindrops, past the ladybirds, past the fence post itself, into a tall green tower of a plant with a hundred seed pods that rattled in the wind like maracas, the strangest and most wonderful thing on the whole farm. Bean's vines, hunting for somewhere worth climbing, leaned into the corner. Kernel's stalks leaned too, the way plants do, toward the friend they couldn't walk to.

And the next spring, when Farmer Meg found the marvelous pods, she saved every seed — Pip's hundred children — and planted them in long brown rows in the Big Field, where you could see them from the gate.

Pip counted them coming up: one, two, three... a hundred little springs.

So that's what Grandmother meant, thought Pip, standing taller than anything — small as a freckle, light as a wish, and the biggest thing on Bramblewick Farm.